

CHALLENGE #14: GET aHead Write-up.

GET aHEAD

Easy

Web Exploitation

picoCTF 2021

AUTHOR: MADSTACKS

Description

Find the flag being held on this server to get ahead of the competition

Additional details will be available after launching your challenge instance.

This challenge launches an instance on demand.

Its current status is:

NOT_RUNNING

Launch Instance

Hints

12

Maybe you have more than 2 choices

115,875 users solved

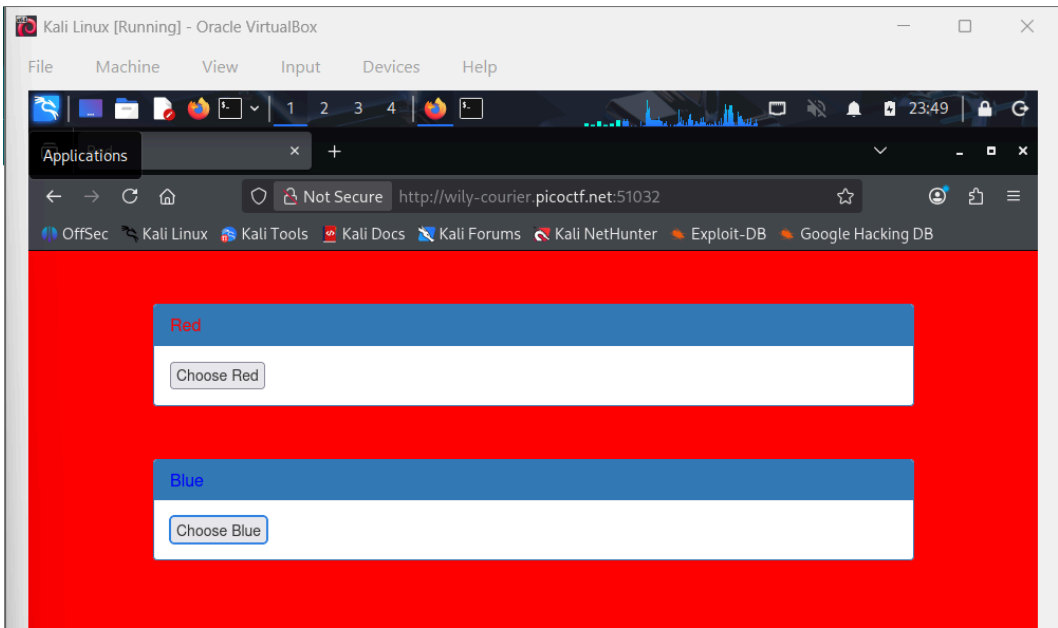
88% Liked

picoCTF{FLAG}

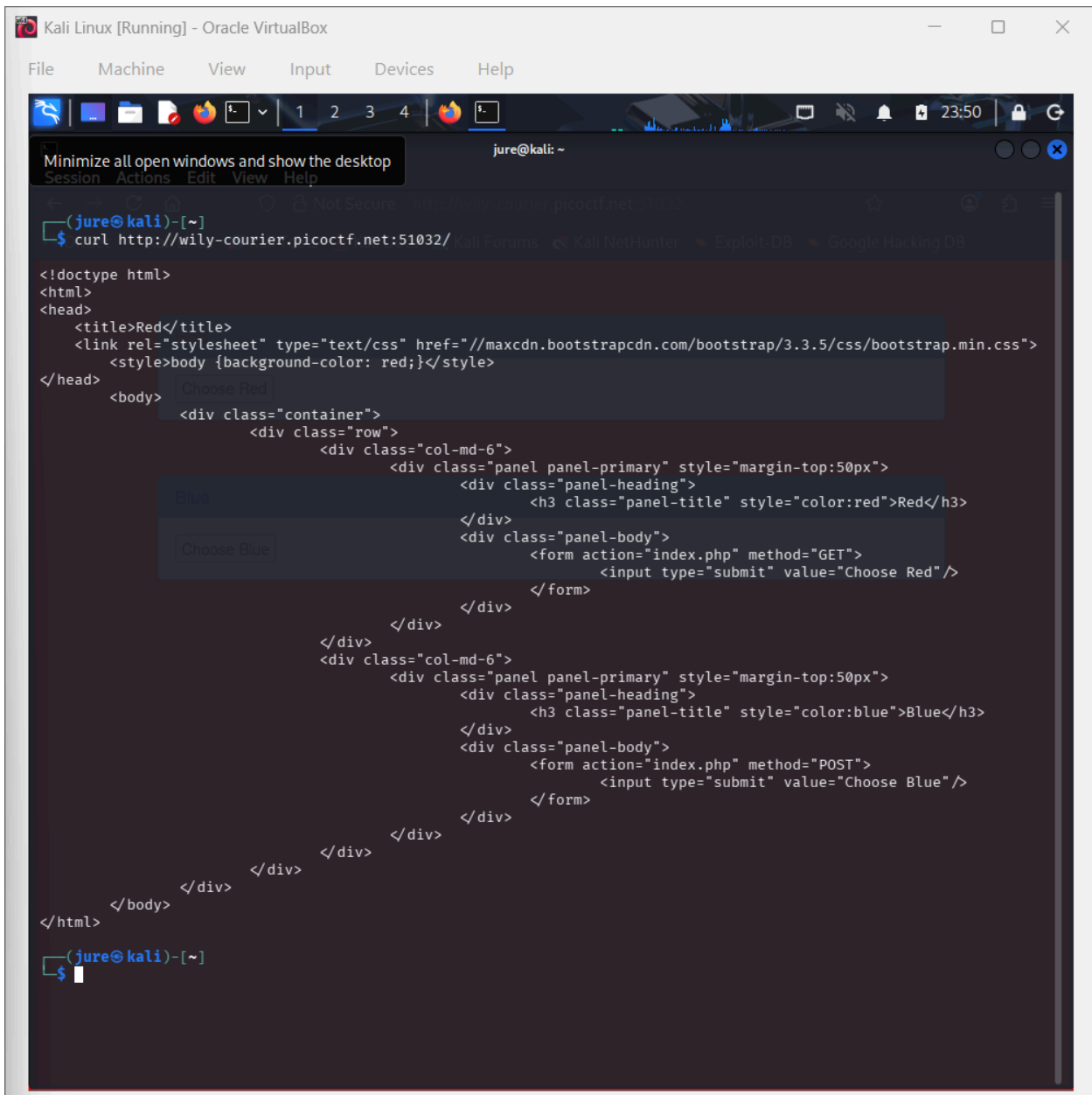
Submit Flag

Solving Process:

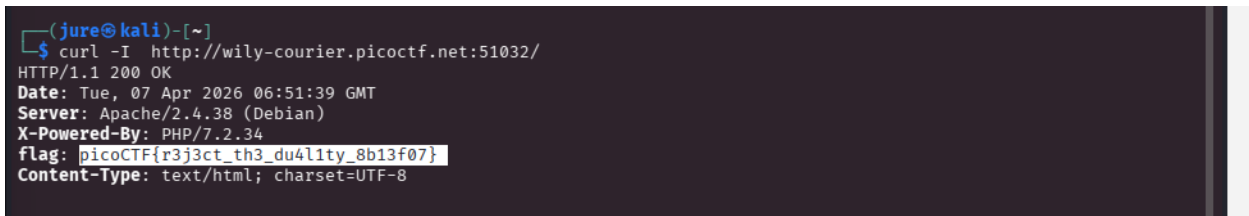
The page appeared very simple, containing only two buttons labeled **Red** and **Blue**. Clicking either button only changed the background color of the webpage. Since the description of the challenge stated **“find the flag behind the server”** and the challenge name was **“Get aHEAD,”** it suggested that the solution might involve using the **HTTP HEAD request**.



To investigate further, the URL of the website was copied and tested using the `curl` command in the terminal. Running the command `curl <URL>` sent a GET request, which returned the full HTML content of the webpage. However, this output did not reveal the flag.



Instead of retrieving the full content, a HEAD request was attempted to obtain only the metadata and headers returned by the server. This was done using the command `curl -I <URL>`. The `-I` option instructs curl to send a HEAD request rather than a GET request.



After executing the command, the server responded with several HTTP response headers, including information such as the server type and content type. While reviewing these headers, the flag was found embedded directly within the server's response header.

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Description

Find the flag being held on this server to get ahead of the competition

http://wily-courier.picoctf.net:51032/

This challenge launches an instance on demand.

Its current status is: **RUNNING**

Instance Time Remaining: **26:53**

Restart Instance

Hints

12

115,875 users solved

88% Liked

picoCTF{r3j3ct_th3_du4l1ty_8b13f07}

Submit Flag

Hurray! You solved this challenge.

Reflection:

This challenge demonstrated how understanding different HTTP request methods can reveal hidden information that is not visible in the webpage itself. By using a HEAD request, it was possible to access server metadata where the flag was stored. The activity highlighted the importance of examining server responses and headers when performing web security analysis.